About the Author



Mary Botham Howitt (1799-1888) was an English poet. She was born at Coleford, in Gloucestershire. She was educated at home and read widely. She commenced writing verses at a very early age. Together with her husband William Howitt, she wrote over 180 books.

3PWJA

Glossary

parlour (n)	-	a tidy room in a house used for entertaining guests
winding (v)	-	a twisting movement or course
weary (v)	-	very tired, especially from hard work
pantry (n)	-	a room where beverages, food, dishes are stored
subtle (adj.)	-	delicate or faint and mysterious
flattering (v)	-	to praise or compliment insincerely
counsellor (n)	-	a person who advises

A. Read the following lines from the poem and answer the questions in a sentence or two.

RBGQS

1. "*The way into my parlour is up a winding stair,*
And I've many curious things to show when you are there"

   a) How can the fly reach the spider's parlour?

   b) What will the fly get to see in the parlour?

2. "*Oh no, no," said the little Fly, "kind Sir, that cannot be,*
I've heard what's in your pantry, and I do not wish to see!"

   a) Is the fly willing to enter the spider's pantry?

   b) Can you guess what was in the pantry?

3. "*Sweet creature!" said the Spider, "You're witty and you're wise,*
How handsome are your gauzy wings, how brilliant are your eyes!"

   a) List the words used by the spider to describe the fly.

   b) Why does the spider say that the fly is witty?

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